

Textual Formality



In this module, you are developing your writing skills. An important aspect of this is understanding how formal or informal your writing should be—this is known as *register*. For Assessment 3, you may be writing to a CEO, so your register needs to be very formal and academic. For Assessment 4, you will be presenting to high-school graduates. In this case, the register can be slightly less formal, but it should still remain professional.

Formality depends on:

- **Genre** (text type)
- **Audience** (e.g., a friend vs. a CEO)
- **Mode** (speaking vs. writing)

1. Watch the video, which explains the degree of formality, using an email as an example.
2. Read about the difference between Latinate and phrasal verbs.
3. Check your understanding of the degree of formality by doing the activity.



Video



Essential: Academic writing

This video discusses issues of formality, audience and register in academic writing.

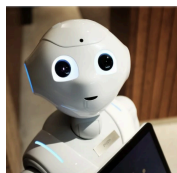
Before watching the video, think about what you already know between formal and informal language.

Now, watch the video to see if your ideas are mentioned.

What is academic writing ➞ (https://www.bilibili.com/video/BV1Wv4y1K7UX/?spm_id_from=333.337.search-card.all.click)



Readings



Language awareness: Phrasal verbs and Latinate

verbs

When you speak, you probably use a lot of phrasal verbs. "The plane **took off** from Sydney". "I **added up** the number of errors".

A phrasal verb is a verb + a particle (another small word - *up, out, in, across*). They are "phrases", hence phrasal verbs.

In academic writing, however, phrasal verbs are usually considered too informal, so it's best to use a Latinate verb (a verb that originated from Latin often through French). "The plane **departed** from Sydney". "I **calculated** the number of errors". Latinate verbs are one verb to replace the phrasal verbs.

Look at the list below. If you are thinking of using some of the phrasal verbs in your written assessment, consider changing it to a Latinate verb.

List of phrasal verbs (informal) and Latinate verbs (formal)



Phrasal verb	Sentence	Latinate verb
add up	James added up the number of affirmative responses.	calculate
buy out	The large company bought out the smaller.	purchase (someone's assets)
buy up	The business's assets were bought up in the auction.	purchase (all of something)
call off	The order was to call off the strike immediately.	cancel
carry on	The meeting will carry on in your absence.	continue

carry out	Sam carried out the research because Jimmy couldn't find the time.	execute
cut out	Because the subsection was not directly relevant to the rest of the paper, Randal had to cut it out .	excise
find out	The purpose of the literature review is find out what has been said on the topic.	discover
get (it) over with (<i>must be split</i>)	Isa and the other participants were happy to get the laborious questionnaire over with .	complete
get across	Lars's paper has too many grammatical mistakes, meaning he couldn't get his message across .	communicate
give up	The outnumbered forces would not give up . He gave up smoking.	surrender stop
hold up	When deadlines approach, a student cannot let anything hold up the completion of an assignment.	delay
leave out	The witness left out a number of important details.	omit
make up	We asked participants to make up a scenario in which they would be content.	fabricate (imagine)
make out	In the darkness he could not make out the size of the camp.	see
pass up	We could not pass up this opportunity to collaborate.	forgo
pass on	The common flu can be passed on through saliva.	transmit
pass out	Our research assistants passed out four-hundred surveys to a random sample of shoppers.	distribute
pick up	This study picks Dekker's research up where he left it.	resume
point out	Hendriks (2010) points out that such a study might be useful.	explain
set up	The equipment's sensitivity meant we had to set it up with utmost care.	arrange
turn down	Regretfully, the board must turn down a number of applicants every year.	reject
use up	The campers were thirsty after they used up the last of the water.	exhaust
back out of	Several subjects backed out of their treatment.	abandon

bear on	Foucault's writings still bear on contemporary thought about prison.	influence
call on	I call on the work of other contemporary thinkers.	utilise
call for	The act of aggression called for immediate response.	necessitate
count on	The question is, should a citizen be able to count on its government to preserve free access to clean water?	rely on
cut down on	Practiced writers cut down on unnecessary adverbs  (https://www.scribbr.com/parts-of-speech/adverbs/) and adjectives  (https://www.scribbr.com/parts-of-speech/adjectives/) .	reduce
come up with	Hannah had to come up with a way to isolate the variable.	invent
fall apart	The board of directors fell apart .	disintegrate
get away	Several of them sought to get away from the cold winter night.	escape
give in	After a long pause for thought, he gave in to the demands.	yield
go on	Bakker went on to win a prestigious award.	continue
hold on to	Sven tried everything, but could not hold on to his youth.	keep
hold out	Bram would hold out until morning when the supplies arrived.	wait
hold out on	Napoleon would not tolerate his generals holding out on him.	hide (something)
look into	We have a hypothesis, but we must look into other possible explanations for the phenomenon.	research
make sure of	To print the name of interviewee, an author must make sure of the interviewee's consent.	ensure
pick up on	The data show various relationships that we had not picked up on .	notice
put up with	The country will put up with a certain number of economic sanctions.	tolerate
take after	This new state takes after its regional neighbours.	resemble
touch on	At the beginning of his speech, Finn found it necessary to touch on the circumstances of the	mention

event.

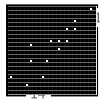


Check your understanding

Formality

Phrasal verbs v. Latinate verbs

Change the phrasal verb for a Latinate verb.



Across

4 call off (6)

7 pass on (8)

8 make sure (6)

9 give up (9)

11 go on (8)

12 take off (6)

13 look into (8)

14 add up (9)



Questions & Answers

Formality

If you have any questions, or would like to discuss answers, please post in the

Textual: Q&A Discussion Forum

(https://canvas.utscollege.edu.au/courses/7983/discussion_topics/198365)